Mike McKeown

Non-Executive Director and Trustee · Commercial and public-service leadership · Digital, AI and cyber governance

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BOARD PROFILE

Non-executive director and charity trustee, with board and governance experience across government, business, not-for-profit and charity organisations. I am an elected Cabinet Member at Cotswold District Council, working under public scrutiny, and founder of a digital and AI transformation consultancy. I have run and grown commercial businesses internationally, and worked on major acquisitions and a private equity carve-out. My specialism is digital transformation, including data, AI and cyber security: I help a board see what a technology investment will cost, what could go wrong and what value it should deliver. I contribute by asking the questions that sharpen a board's debate, and by coaching and challenging the executive while leaving ownership with them.

WHAT I BRING TO A BOARD

- **Strategy, deals and due diligence.** Ran and grew an EMEA public sector business of over £300M; due diligence and integration on two multi-billion-pound acquisitions; part of the team that created Synamedia through a private equity carve-out; adviser on venture fundraising.
- **Governance and constructive challenge.** Charity trustee and director; chair of the council's AI Oversight Board and Climate Change Board; co-founder of a community benefit society.
- **Public accountability.** Accountable under public scrutiny, to full council and scrutiny committees, within statutory duties and a fixed budget.
- **Digital transformation, data and cyber risk.** Started my career at GCHQ; led AI transformation at an EU-listed cybersecurity company and wrote its board-approved Responsible AI framework (EU AI Act, GDPR, DORA). I translate technology into cost, risk and value.
- **Coaching, people and board chemistry.** Mentor on the Stepping Up inclusive leadership programme since January 2023, including a senior Ministry of Defence manager who went on to a Director role; coach executive teams through change; hands-on experience of hiring, organisation design and difficult restructuring, including a major move of engineering and support to India.
- **International and cross-cultural leadership.** Led teams drawn from 16 countries, and worked with customers, partners and colleagues across Europe, the Middle East, Africa, Asia (including China and India) and the Americas. At ease with different cultures, and with bringing very different people to a shared view.

BOARD AND GOVERNANCE ROLES

Trustee and Non-Executive Director, Gloucestershire Rural Community Council (GRCC) Mar 2026 – present

The county's rural community development charity. I share responsibility for strategy, financial sustainability and governance, with a focus on digital, data and the responsible use of AI.

- Joined a board working group, with the chief executive and head of finance, that strengthened the business case for a major digital platform investment: an itemised budget, data protection and security testing designed in, and clear conditions before live personal data goes onto the system.

Cabinet Member for Digital and Climate, and Chair of the AI Oversight Board, Cotswold District Council May 2023 – present

Executive member of the Cabinet, answering to full council and scrutiny committees. Sets policy and direction and holds officers to account for delivery, much as a non-executive does.

- Co-authored the Responsible AI Policy and AI Strategy with the Chief Information Officer, adopted by Cabinet in April 2026. Chair the AI Oversight Board (Chief Executive, Chief Finance Officer, Chief Information Officer and Leader of the Council), which scrutinises proposals, tests evidence of benefit and risk, tracks delivery and set up an AI Champions programme.
- Results: 40%+ faster decisions on planning applications with an AI planning system supporting officers; about eight weeks of officer time saved analysing 2,000 Local Plan consultation responses; around 250 officers and members using Microsoft Copilot under the policy.
- Lead the climate programme and chair the Climate Change Board (since 2025): the council has risen more than 60 places on the national Climate Action Scorecard. Chaired Climate Leadership Gloucestershire in 2024.

Co-Founder and Director, Thames Head Community Energy Jan 2022 – present

- Set up a community benefit society with a board of seven directors to develop community-owned solar. Raised £18,000 through community crowdfunding and secured £40,000 of feasibility funding from the South West Net Zero Hub for a 5 to 10 MW scheme.

Independent Adviser to Leadership Teams, through Human-AI Systems — Mar 2026 – present

- Advise boards and leadership teams on digital and AI strategy, risk and governance: creating options, identifying risks and opportunities, and coaching executives through change.

Advisory Board Member, Gravitas Tech and Solutions, a US AI start-up — Apr 2026 – present

- Advise the founders on strategy and fundraising: investor readiness, valuation and dilution, SAFEs versus priced equity, and an investor-grade financial model covering scenarios, costs, cash burn and runway.

Adviser and Shareholder, GSM, an innovation and venture development company — 2021 – 2024

- Advised founders and venture teams on commercial strategy, funding and market entry in health technology, IoT and supply-chain ventures.

Earlier: Committee member since 2000 and former Chair, Lower Mill Estate Homeowners Association (400 households); Parish Councillor, Somerford Keynes (2007 – 2019).

EXECUTIVE CAREER

Founder and Managing Director, Human-AI Systems — Mar 2026 – present

- AI transformation consultancy: advises organisations on AI strategy and governance, builds practical AI systems, and trains teams. Co-created the From Prompt to Autopilot programme with John Clifton.

Senior Director, AI Transformation and Sales Enablement, Verimatrix (EU-listed cybersecurity) — Sep 2022 – Mar 2026

- Appointed by the CEO to lead AI transformation across a nine-country business. Wrote the Responsible AI framework, took it to the board for approval and led the steering group that reported progress to the executive committee.
- Measured in business terms: around 10% better win rates in the SaaS business, about an hour a day back for every engineer, and around 30% fewer routine support tickets. Scaled the partner programme to more than 120 partners.

Senior Director, Sales Enablement and SDR, Kaltura — Jan 2022 – Sep 2022

- Built the company's first global sales enablement function across its media and telecoms markets.

Founder and Managing Director, Somerford Tech, my own consultancy — Jul 2020 – Jan 2022

- Advised technology companies on go-to-market, business development and digital transformation, including a £100K+ video platform win with a European broadcaster for Spicy Mango Technology.

Senior Director, Business Development and Operations, Synamedia — 2018 – 2020

- Part of the team that handled the sale of Cisco's service provider video business to Permira, creating Synamedia, an independent company of 3,500 people, then helped separate it from Cisco.
- Business lead for the new company's own CRM, moving off Cisco's systems early and saving millions in charges. Led the move of a substantial part of engineering and support to India: a difficult change for the people affected, which cut annual costs by millions while keeping service to customers running.

Senior leadership roles, Cisco — 1994 – 2018

- Led the EMEA education and local government business, over £300M a year, growing it by 20% and lifting win rates in key segments from around 40% to 60%.
- Part of the teams that carried out due diligence on, and then integrated, Tandberg and NDS. Senior Director of Business Development for the video business across EMEA, Asia Pacific and China, leading a team of twelve.
- Sales Director for the BT Group relationship; launched the Cisco Networking Academy across Europe. Selected for the Cisco Accelerated Development Programme.

Earlier: EMEA presales and product management, Network Systems Corporation (1990 – 1994); project manager and network architect, GCHQ (1986 – 1990).

COMMITTEES, INTERESTS AND AVAILABILITY

- **Committees:** audit and risk (including technology, cyber and data risk); digital, technology or transformation; quality and performance; people and remuneration.
- **Conflicts:** I declare my interests at every board and never sell my consultancy's services to a board I sit on. As an elected councillor, I do not take roles where the organisation's business comes before my council.
- **Availability:** two to three days a month per role. Based in the Cotswolds; happy to travel.

EDUCATION AND DEVELOPMENT

BSc (Hons) Computer Science, Economics and Psychology, Swansea University · Mini-MBA, INSEAD · UK100 Climate Leadership Academy (one of 20 councillors selected nationally)